

Gambling

prc-gambling

Christian Ethics · Money · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

score 1.000
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Gambling for gain at another's loss is unwise and contrary to neighbor-love; it is to be avoided as a regular practice.

In plain language

The proposition asks whether gambling for gain at another person's loss is unwise, contrary to loving a neighbor, and something to avoid as a habit. The first thing the words show is that no Greek or Hebrew term in the whole Bible means gambling, a wager, or a game of chance played for money. Any verdict has to be assembled from texts about money, work, and the lot, not read off a single word. The signal in those texts is consistent. In 1 Timothy 6 the danger is the settled wish to be rich, called a snare, and the rare word philarguria, love of money, is called a root of all kinds of evils. Proverbs 13:11 sets wealth from hebel, vapor or emptiness, which shrinks, against wealth gathered by hand, which grows. Proverbs 28:20 and 22 add the verbs 'uts and bahal for hastening to be rich, and warn that the one in a hurry will not go unpunished. Ephesians 4:28 tells the former thief to labor with his own hands and produce something good so he has a surplus to share with someone in need. Together these favor patient earning, contentment, and giving over craving, shortcutting, and taking. That pattern leans toward the proposition. The honest reason the verdict is contested is a scope problem in the vocabulary, not a contradiction in the texts. The words address the disposition behind acquisition, the velocity of it, and the neighbor effect of it, but they do not name a wager, so the step from love of money or hasty wealth to gambling specifically is an application rather than a direct statement. Two further texts keep the question open. Proverbs 16:33 and Acts 1:26 treat the lot, goral and kleros, as a decisional instrument under God, never a commercial wager. The parable of the talents in Matthew 25 commends trading at risk for a return. The lexicon does not draw the line between sanctioned productive risk and a zero-sum wager taken from a neighbor. So the surrounding ethic is dense and pan-canonical, but the target practice is unnamed, which is why honest readers land in different places on the same words.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0213	אוץ	'uts	to hasten	10
H0926	בהל	bahal	to dismay	31
H1215	בצע	betsa	unjust-gain	22
H1486	גורל	goral	allotted	71
H1892	הבל	hebel	vanity	64
H1952	הון	hon	substance	25
H3068	יהוה	yehovah	LORD	
H4591	מעט	ma'at	to diminish	22
H5392	נשך	neshekh	interest	

H6238	אַשַׁר	ashar	to enrich	
H6908	קָבַט	qabats	to gather	119
G0018	ἀγαθός	agathos	good	
G0684	ἀπώλεια	apoleia	destruction	19
G1014	βούλομαι	boulomai	to plan	40
G1937	ἐπιθυμέω	epithumeō	to long for	
G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithumia	desire	38
G2038	ἐργάζομαι	ergazomai	to work	41
G2770	κερδαίνω	kerdainō	to gain	
G2812	κλέπτης	kleptēs	thief	
G2813	κλέπτω	klepto	to steal	13
G2819	κλῆρος	kleros	lot	12
G2872	κοπιᾶω	kopiao	to labor	24
G2975	λαγχάνω	lagchanō	to choose by lot	
G3330	μεταδίδωμι	metadidomi	to share	5
G3639	ὀλεθρος	olethros	destructive	4
G3713	ὀρέγω	orego	to aspire	3
G3803	παγίς	pagis	trap	5
G4123	πλεονέκτης	pleonektēs	greedy	
G4124	πλεονεξία	pleonexia	greediness	10
G4147	πλουτέω	pluteo	be rich	12
G4491	ρίζα	rhiza	root	17
G5365	φιλαργυρία	philarguria	love of money	1
G5366	φιλάργυρος	philarguros	money-loving	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

No Hebrew or Greek lemma in the canon names gambling, a wager, or a game of chance for money. The proposition is reached only by analogia scripturae from adjacent money-ethics texts, and there the lexical signal is dense and consistent: the settled wish to be rich is condemned (1Tim.6.9-10 via boulomai-plutein, epithumia, orego, philarguria as a New Testament hapax), wealth from emptiness is contrasted with wealth gathered by hand (Prov.13.11 via hon, hebel, qabats-al-yad, ma'at versus rabah), hastening to be rich is censured (Prov.28.20-22 via 'uts and bahal with hon and pluteo cognates), and the post-theft ethic is productive labor that yields a surplus to share (Eph.4.28 via klepto, kopiao, ergazomai, agathon, metadidomi). That converging witness leans the application toward affirmation. Two complicating patterns keep the verdict properly contested: in the canon the lot, goral and kleros, is consistently a decisional or portion-assigning instrument under divine providence (Prov.16.33, Prov.18.18, Acts.1.26, allotment passages in Numbers and Joshua) and never a wager for gain, so it neither warrants nor forbids commercial chance; and trading at risk for return is commended (Matt.25.16 via ergazomai-en-autois). The words address the disposition, the velocity, the means, and the neighbor effect of acquisition, but they do not isolate gambling from other forms of acquisitive risk. The verdict is therefore disputed on scope grounds, with medium confidence because the surrounding ethic is pan-canonical and stable even

though the target practice is unnamed.

Scripture

1Tim.6.9 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1014 βούλομαι, G4147 πλουτέω, G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G3803 παγίς, G3639 ὀλεθρος, G0684 ἀπώλεια

Force. Hoi boulomenoi ploutein, those resolving to be rich, fall into temptation and a snare and many senseless and harmful desires that sink anthropoi into olethron kai apoleian, ruin and destruction. The articular present participle boulomenoi names a settled volitional disposition, not a single transaction. The lexical weight rests on wanting wealth and its self-destructive end state, so any acquisition pattern driven by that disposition is caught, but the grammar does not single out one means.

1Tim.6.10 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5365 φιλαργυρία, G3713 ὁρέγω, G4491 ρίζα

Force. Philarguria, a New Testament hapax legomenon, is called rhiza panton ton kakon, a root of all kinds of evils, and some oregomenoi, reaching out for it, were led astray from the faith and pierced themselves with many pains. The hapax status means the sense is anchored only by the cognate philarguros, found at Luke.16.14 and 2Tim.3.2 where it describes a settled love of money. The censure targets the affection itself. Gambling is reached only as one possible instance of that affection in action.

Prov.13.11 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H1952 הון, H1892 הֶבֶל, H6908 קָבֶט, H4591 מַעַט

Force. Hon mehebel yim'at we-qobets al-yad yarbeh. Wealth from hebel, vapor or emptiness, dwindles, while one who gathers by hand, qobets al-yad, increases it. The proverb's antithetic two-line structure pairs hebel against al-yad, contrasting a quick or insubstantial source against patient hand-by-hand accumulation. Hebel is a general term for what is fleeting or insubstantial, used widely in Ecclesiastes and the prophets, not a gambling-specific word, so the principle reaches windfall acquisition broadly and gambling only by inclusion.

Eph.4.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2813 κλέπτω, G2872 κοπιάω, G2038 ἐργάζομαι, G0018 ἀγαθός, G3330 μεταδίδωμι

Force. Ho klepton meketi klepteto, the one stealing must no longer steal, but rather kopiato ergazomenos tais idiais chersin to agathon, must labor working the good with his own hands, hina eche metadidonai to chreian echonti, so that he may have to share with the one having need. The hina clause sets the purpose of labor as surplus available for the neighbor, the inverse of acquisition that subtracts from a neighbor without producing value. The pattern condemns net transfer from a needy other and commends productive value creation, but does not name commercial chance as such.

Prov.28.20 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0213 אוי, H6238 מַהֵר

Force. An expansion of the Prov.13.11 pattern. The faithful man abounds with blessings, but he who hastens, 'ats, to be rich will not go unpunished. The verb 'uts marks velocity of acquisition, not the means. Paired with Prov.28.22 where one with an evil eye hastens, nivhal, after wealth and does not know that want will come on him, the proverbial witness censures shortcut enrichment generally, with gambling as a clear but unnamed instance.

Prov.16.33 · complicates · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H1486 גִּוְרָל; H3068 יְקוּהַ,

Force. Bacheq yutal et ha-goral u-me-YHWH kol mishpato. The lot is cast into the lap, and its every judgment is from YHWH. The lot, goral, is a decisional instrument, not a wager. Across 71 occurrences in the Hebrew canon the goral assigns inheritance (Numbers, Joshua), settles disputes (Prov.18.18), identifies a guilty party (Jonah.1.7, Josh.7.14), and is abused by enemies to divide captives or spoil (Joel.3.3, Obad.1.11, Nah.3.10). In the New Testament the kleros functions identically for apostolic selection (Acts.1.26) and inheritance (Col.1.12, 1Pet.5.3). The canon's chance device is for discernment or allotment, never for transfer of property from a willing loser to a winner.

Matt.25.16 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2038 ἐργάζομαι, G2770 κερδαίνω

Force. Ergasato en autois kai ekerdesen alla pente. The faithful servant in the parable of the talents traded with the entrusted sum and gained five more. The verb ergazomai of commercial activity and kerdaino of profit legitimize value-bearing risk for return, and the master commends, not censures, the surplus. The text positions sanctioned risk-taking inside an ethic of stewardship, leaving the boundary between commended productive risk and condemned zero-sum wager underspecified at the lexical level.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Tim.6.9	1Tim.1.9	tsk	1
1Tim.6.9	1Tim.3.7	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	Exod.20.15	tsk	1
1Tim.6.10	Luke.16.14	tsk	1
1Tim.6.10	2Tim.3.2	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.10.2	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.28.20	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.28.22	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.20.21	tsk	1
Prov.13.11	Prov.13.22	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	Prov.13.11	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	1Thess.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.4.28	2Thess.3.10	tsk	1
Prov.16.33	Prov.18.18	tsk	1
Prov.16.33	Acts.1.26	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Prov.16.33 · addressed

The goral lap-cast is the canon's nearest analog to a chance device, but its 71 Hebrew occurrences and the parallel kleros usage in Acts.1.26 and the Gospels' garment scene at the cross consistently frame the lot as a decisional or allotment instrument under divine sovereignty, never as a wager for gain from another's loss. Lexically the device does not authorize gambling for profit because the canon's chance instrument is not a commercial instrument.

Matt.25.16 · addressed

The parable commends commercial risk-taking that produces value, ergazomai plus kerdaino, on entrusted capital. The lexicon does not supply a term that distinguishes value-creating risk from zero-sum wagering, so the proposition's scope is the unresolved part: the words affirm sanctioned productive risk and condemn the disposition of craving wealth, but they do not draw the line at gambling specifically. This is an honest lexical limit, not a textual contradiction.

Joel.3.3 · addressed

Casting lots for captured people, weyaddu goral, and a parallel pattern at Obad.1.11 and Nah.3.10 use the chance device for hostile zero-sum transfer. The contexts are war atrocities, not commerce, and the texts condemn the perpetrators. They confirm a canonical line against using a chance device to distribute what belongs to a wronged other, which adjoins the proposition's neighbor-loss concern but still does not target wagering for money.

Luke.16.14 · addressed

The cognate philarguros describes those who scoffed at Jesus' teaching on money, and 2Tim.3.2 lists philarguroi among the marks of the last-days character. Together with the 1Tim.6.10 hapax philarguria, these three NT occurrences fix a stable lexical sense for love of money as a moral failure, which secures the principle but still leaves the application step to gambling underdetermined by vocabulary.

Concordance traversed

G5365, G5366, G1939, G1937, G3713, G1014, G4147, G3803, G3639, G0684, G4491, G4124, G4123, G2813, G2812, G2038, G2872, G3330, G2819, G2975, H1486, H1952, H1892, H6908, H4591, H1215, H0213, H0926, H5392

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

No variant units supplied in the bundle and none of the cited verses falls inside the open-cbgm 3 John sample. The verdict does not turn on any contested reading. NT anchors are well attested in the standard manuscript witness.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. practical_wisdom_application, strict_lexical_minimalism, neighbor_love_ethic

[analogia scripturae](#) invoked

practical_wisdom_application: for · Reading 1Tim.6.9-10, Prov.13.11, Prov.28.20-22, and Eph.4.28 as a converging ethic of patient labor, contentment, surplus for the needy neighbor, and condemnation of hastening to wealth yields support for the proposition. Gambling as a regular practice fits the snare of boulomenoi ploutein, the hebel pattern of vapor wealth that dwindles, and the inverse of the productive labor commanded after theft.

strict_lexical_minimalism: null · Confining the verdict to what a gambling-specific lemma demands yields no result, because no such lemma is attested in the canon and the cited texts condemn dispositions, velocities, and categories broader than gambling. By this lens the proposition cannot be settled from the text without reading in a category the words do not name.

neighbor_love_ethic: for · Eph.4.28's surplus-for-the-needy purpose clause, paired with the cognates klepto and arpax in the broader Pauline vice catalogs (1Cor.5.10, 1Cor.6.10), supports the proposition where gambling resembles a net transfer from a willing loser to a winner without value creation. This lens is silent where gambling involves no neighbor loss in practice, e.g., between consenting parties of comparable means, which the lexicon does not adjudicate.

stewardship_with_sanctioned_risk: disputed · Matt.25.16 with ergazomai and kerdaino, plus the merchant of Prov.31.14-18, plus Eccl.11.1-2 with shelach lachmecha al-pene ha-mayim, normalize productive risk-taking under

stewardship. From this lens the proposition is true only when the practice in view is zero-sum and reckless, and the lexicon does not draw that line, so the verdict is contested. This is the strongest minority lens and must be represented in its full force.

The four lenses diverge by what they take to be the controlling category. The lexical witness is dense for the surrounding ethic and silent on the target practice, which is why honest readings legitimately differ. The verdict above reports that pattern rather than picking a lens.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Wagering money or goods on a chance outcome where one party's gain is another party's loss: assess whether the canon's money, lot, and labor lexemes bear on it.

The original stem embeds three conclusions: unwise, contrary to neighbor-love, and to be avoided as a regular practice. Each is an evaluative verdict rather than a neutral description of the act. The neutralized form strips those conclusions so the lexical pattern is assessed on the practice itself. The verdict above is still derived against the original stem and is reported as disputed because the lexicon supplies a strong adjacent ethic but no term that names or delimits gambling. No verdict was flipped from the prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5365
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2819
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4147
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1892
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1486
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0213
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.6.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.6.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.4.28
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.25.16
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.13.11
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.16.33
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.28.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Prov.13.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.4.28
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Tim.6.10

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · complicating-unresolved